



Module 3: God's Warnings About the Flood

SESSIONS 11-14

Storm clouds begin to gather as God's good world is filled with injustice. How does Yahweh respond to the outcry of violence in his creation?

Session 11: The Rebellion of the Sons of Adam

Key Takeaways

- Being in covenant with God has nothing to do with being ethnically a part of Abraham's family. It means imitating Abraham's trust in God.
- The outcry of the ruined land is a key motif showing us how human corruption and suffering prompts God to act.
- The flood is part of the biblical pattern where we see God's judgment and his mercy at work simultaneously.

The Rebellion of the Sons of Adam: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 6:5-12

The Rebellion of the Sons of Adam

a 5 **And Yahweh saw** that **multiplied (רב)** was the badness of **humanity** **in the land** ,
b and every purpose of the plans of **his heart** was only bad all the day,

a' 6 and Yahweh **regretted that he made** **humanity** **in the land** .
b' And he was pained in **his heart**.

7 **And Yahweh said** ,
"I will wipe away **humanity** that I created from the face of **the ground** ,
from **humanity**
to animals
to creeping things
and to birds of the skies
for **I regret that I have made** them."

8 And/But Noah found favor **in the eyes of Yahweh**.

a 9 These are the **birth**-generations of Noah;
Noah was a righteous one,
b blameless in his generation;

Noah walked with *Elohim*;
 a 10 and Noah **birthed** three sons: Shem, Ham, and Japheth.

a 11 And **the land** was **ruined** *before Elohim*.
 b And **the land** was filled with violence,
 a' 12 and *Elohim saw* **the land** : and behold, **it** was **ruined**,
 b' for **all flesh** had **ruined** its/his way upon **the land** .

Genesis 6:1-12. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

The Righteous One is Delivered from Death

Noah is described with two new terms (righteous and blameless), and one term already used of Enoch (walked with God). The analogy between Noah and Enoch has a clear purpose.

Life and Outcome	Enoch	Noah
"walked with God"	5:22 and Enoch walked with God three hundred years after he became the father of Methuselah, and he caused the birth of sons and daughters, ²³ and all the days of Enoch were three hundred and sixty-five years. ²⁴ And Enoch walked with God ;	6:9 Noah was a righteous one, blameless in his generation; Noah walked with God.
Delivered from death	²⁴ and he was not, for God took him.	Rescued from death through the ark
<i>Life and Outcome of Enoch and Noah. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).</i>		

The goal of this analogy is to fill out the picture of what it means to walk with God.

- Just as Enoch walked with God and was delivered from death, so Noah walks with God and is delivered from death.
- Just as Enoch walked with God, so Noah was righteous and blameless.

Genesis 17:1 NASB

Now when Abram was ninety-nine years old, the LORD appeared to Abram and said to him, "I am God Almighty; **walk before me**, and be **blameless**.

Genesis 24:40 NASB*

[Abraham] said to me, “**Yahweh, before whom I have walked**, will send his angel with you to make your journey successful, and you will take a wife for my son from my relatives and from my father’s house”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 48:15 NASB

[Jacob] blessed Joseph, and said, “The God **before whom my fathers Abraham and Isaac walked**, the God who has been my shepherd all my life to this day”

To be righteous means to do right by Yahweh, by trusting and following his wisdom; to do right by one’s neighbor; to be blameless means to live with ethical integrity, as a morally “whole” person.

Genesis 15:5-6 NASB

⁵ And he took him outside and said, “Now look toward the heavens, and count the stars, if you are able to count them.” And he said to him, “So shall your descendants be.” ⁶ Then he believed in the LORD; and he **reckoned it to him as righteousness**.

Psalms 15:1-3 NASB

¹ O LORD, who may abide in your tent?
Who may dwell on your holy hill?

² **He who walks with blamelessness, and practices righteousness**,
and speaks truth in his heart.

³ He does not slander with his tongue,
nor does evil to his neighbor,
nor takes up a reproach against his friend

This opening scene of the flood narrative shows a density of key words that will become thematic for the flood design pattern throughout the Hebrew Bible. All of the words are keyed off the scene of Noah’s birth name in 5:29.

Genesis 5:29 NASB*

And [Lamech] called his name **Noah (נח)** saying, “This one will **give us comfort (נחם)** from our work and from the toil of our hands from the ground which the LORD has cursed.”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 6:5-13 Instructor's Translation

⁵ And Yahweh saw that multiplied was the badness of humanity in the land,
and every **purpose (מחשבת)** of the plans of his heart was only bad all the day,

⁶ and Yahweh **regretted (נחם)** that he made humanity in the land,
and he was pained in his heart.

⁷ And Yahweh said,
“I **will wipe away (מחה)** humanity that I created from the face of the ground,
from humanity to animals to creeping things and to birds of the skies
for I **regret (נחם)** that I have made them.”

⁸ But **Noah** (נח) found **favor** (חן) in the eyes of Yahweh.

⁹ These are the birth-generations of **Noah** (נח);

Noah (נח) was a righteous one,

blameless in his generation;

Noah (נח) walked with *Elohim*;

¹⁰ and **Noah** (נח) birthed three sons: Shem, **Ham** (חם), and Japheth.

¹¹ And the land was **ruined** (שחת) before *Elohim*,

and the land was filled with **violence** (חמס)

¹² and *Elohim* saw the land: and behold,

it was **ruined** (נשחת) for all flesh had **ruined** (שחת) its/his way upon the land.

¹³ And *Elohim* said to **Noah** (נח) "The end of all flesh has come before me,

because the land is filled with **violence** (חמס) because of them,

and behold, I am going to **ruin** (משחית) the land."

Key Theme Word Associations

Key Theme	Word Associations
comfort/regret (nakh am / ם)	Noah (n oa kh / נח) favor (kh e n / חן) ruined (n ish kh at / נשחת)
comfort/regret (na kham / נחם)	purpose (m a kh shevet / מחשבת) wipe away (m a kh ah / מחשבת) Ham (kh a m / חם) violence (kh a m as / חמס) ruin (m ash kh it / משחית)
Genesis 6 Wordplay. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).	

The wordplay associations are dense and point to the main themes of the flood story as a whole.

Summary: Despite the evil **purposes** and **violence** of humanity that have **ruined** the land, and despite God's **regret** and his decree to accelerate the **ruin** of the land, God views *Noah*, the man of *rest*, with *favor*, and delivers him to *bring comfort*.

Righteous Noah, a Ruined World, and a Regretful God

The violence in the land is directly connected to the preceding two narratives in 4:1-26 and 6:1-4. Both narratives highlight the role of human and cosmic violence and disorder in the land.